Glossary — Words We Use Precisely

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This course brainwashes you into an ambitious, conversion-heavy mindset — and vocabulary is the delivery mechanism. These definitions are fixed. We will correct you in check-ins. Kindly. Every time.

The Core Five

Term	Definition	What it is NOT
VALIDATION	Somebody opens their wallet.	Interviews, likes, signups, compliments — that's all *signal*.
SIGNAL	Evidence below the wallet line (interviews, clicks, signups, waitlists). Earns you the right to run the next, more expensive test.	Proof. Signal never "validates" anything.
PROTOTYPE	A very quickly built slice of the product that your user base is **willing to pay money for**.	A mockup, a Figma flow, a demo video. Those are *props* — useful for collecting signal, but nobody pays for a prop.
CUSTOMER	A user who pays.	A user. A user who doesn't pay is a **fan**. Fans are lovely and pay no rent.
KILL	An evidence-based decision to stop — announced, documented, celebrated.	Failure. In this course a rigorous kill is a gradeable win (see the rubric).

The Supporting Cast

Term	Definition
User	Someone who actually uses the product. Not someone who said they would.
Pilot	A *paid* engagement with fixed scope, fixed duration (2–4 weeks), agreed success criteria, and a conversion path to recurring revenue. An unpaid pilot is a favor.
MVP	The smallest thing that can trigger validation (a wallet opening). If it can't be paid for, it's not viable — it's minimal and useless.
Concierge	Delivering the outcome as a manual service, zero product. Fully legitimate revenue; the highest-signal prototype there is.
Traction	Customers paying *repeatedly* — same offer, more than once, without custom scope. One favor-sale is an anecdote.
Revenue quality	The ladder: custom project < paid pilot < repeatable offer < recurring subscription. The leaderboard ranks quality, not just quantity.
Hair-on-fire segment	The people who have the problem worst: frequency × intensity × current spend — and would text you at 2am about it.
Budget authority	The person who can say yes to money. The pain-haver and the budget-holder are often different people; your Pain Map carries both.
Vision / Moonshot	The mountain: market ceiling, why it matters, who joins you. Picks *which* wedges are worth driving.

Term	Definition
Wedge	The first foothold: a problem so specific you can win it this semester. Where the vision touches the ground.
Threshold	A pass/fail number written and dated BEFORE the test (Kill Criteria Log). Anything committed after seeing data is commentary, not a threshold.
Monkey first	Test the hardest, most uncertain assumption first — never the pedestal that feels like progress.
GPK	Go / Pivot / Kill — decided on pre-committed criteria, scored on artifacts (framework 03).
Founder-problem fit	Where your unique insight, a problem worth solving and what your team can execute overlap. Said in one to three sentences, it is your early-stage pitch (Module 02).
DVF	Module 02's one gate from many ideas to one. Desirable, viable, feasible, each score marked heard (name the person) or assumed. Viable asks what people spend today, not what they say they would pay.

Say This, Not That

Don't say	Say
"We validated the problem with 10 interviews."	"We collected strong interview *signal*. Validation starts when a wallet opens."
"We have 50 users!"	"We have 50 users and 0 customers — conversion is this week's job."
"Our prototype is almost ready to show."	"Our prototype is live; 3 strangers used it; 1 paid."
"The pilot went great, they loved it."	"The pilot converted at €400/month starting March."
"We failed — the idea didn't work."	"We killed it on evidence: threshold was 10%, we measured 2%. Here's the autopsy and the next test."
"We're pre-revenue."	Never say this. You're "three asks away from revenue" — and you know the three names.

Used in every check-in from Module 00 onward. If a slide, workshop, or homework uses these words loosely, flag it — the language IS the mindset.